pulses that they were already entitled to get. She highlighted that this package would focus primarily on migrant workers and daily wage labourers and was essentially designed to help the nation's poor tackle the financial difficulties arising out of the outbreak. She said, 'A package is ready for the poor who need immediate help like migrant workers and urban and rural poor. No one will go hungry.'[4] In addition, she announced, 'Safai karamcharis [cleaners], ward-boys, nurses, paramedics, technicians, doctors and specialists and other healthcare workers would be covered by a special insurance scheme. Any health professional who while treating COVID-19 patients meets with some accident, then he/she would be compensated with an amount of 50 lakh rupees under the scheme.'[5] Several direct cash transfers were announced for some of our most vulnerable groups. Nearly 8.9 crore farmers would immediately receive the first instalment of ₹2,000 as part of the PM-Kisan Samman Nidhi. Wages under the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MNREGA) would also increase by ₹2,000 per worker as additional income for daily wage workers. Three crore senior citizens, persons with disabilities and widows would also be entitled to receive a one-time additional amount of ₹1,000 in two instalments. Twenty crore Jan-Dhan women account holders would receive a direct transfer of ₹5,000 per month and that families below the poverty line would receive free gas cylinders for the next three months. In addition, collateral-free loans would be doubled to help seven crore women working in self-help groups. The government would bear the cost of the employee provident fund contribution on part of both the employer and the employee over the next three months. She also permitted workers to draw up to 75 per cent advance from the existing credit in the employee provident fund or three months' salary. More funds were announced to benefit construction workers as well.[6]

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The lockdown itself and subsequent infection-control measures that the government would put in place would have to stand in the court of law. For this, the National Disaster Management Authority, of which the prime minister is the chairman, exercised its powers under the National Disaster Management Act, 2005 and issued an order directing the ministries and